

MORPHOLOGY & SPELLING

High School Foundations | Unit 1

Prefixes contra- & counter-



Today I am learning that contra- and counter- can carry the idea against, opposite or in response.

1 Learn the Meaning

The prefixes contra- and counter- both signal opposition. Contra- often appears in formal or technical words, while counter- is common in words about answering, balancing or acting against something.

contraflow

flow in the opposite direction

counterargument

an argument in response

contraindication

a reason against an action

counteract

act against an effect

2 Build the Word

Add contra- or counter- to the base or word clue. Build the word, then write a short meaning clue.

Base / clue	Add	New word	Meaning clue
flow	contra-		
indication	contra-		
argument	counter-		
act	counter-		
balance	counter-		

3 Read and Notice

Read the passage below.

During a research project, Maya noticed that contra- and counter- appeared in very different kinds of texts. A transport article described a contraflow lane that allowed buses to travel opposite the usual direction. A health information text used contraindication for a reason against using a particular treatment. Both words carried a clear idea of opposition.

In a debate article, one writer presented a counterargument and a counterclaim against the main position. Another writer offered a counterexample to challenge a broad generalisation. In an engineering report, a counterweight helped counterbalance a heavy gate, while a vibration pad helped counteract unwanted movement. Maya concluded that the two prefixes often point to something acting against, opposite to, or in response to something else.



Highlight the contra- and counter- words. Underline the base or whole-word clue, then decide how each word shows opposition.

4 Word Detective

Choose one contra- or counter- word from the passage and investigate its structure and meaning.

- Write a target word from the passage.

- Which prefix does it use: contra- or counter-?

- What base, word or meaning clue can you identify?

- How does the whole word show opposition or response?

5 Sort the Words

Sort the words by the kind of opposition.

contraflow

contraindication

counterargument

counterclaim

counterexample

counteract

counterbalance

counterweight

Opposite / against

Response / balancing

6 Use It in Writing



Complete the sentence starters.

- A strong counterargument should _____

- Use contraflow, counteract or counterexample in a sentence that shows its meaning.



Parent check

Tick the skills your learner has demonstrated.

- ☐ Recognises the contra-/counter- opposition clue
- ☐ Identifies a base or whole-word meaning clue
- ☐ Distinguishes opposite from response/balancing meanings
- ☐ Reads and uses target words in context



Capture idea:

Find a contra- or counter- word in an academic or information text. Record the word, its context, and explain the opposition clue.